

# Prefix Sum + HashMap Templates

Core idea: subarray sum  $[l, r] = \text{prefix}[r+1] - \text{prefix}[l]$  .  
To find a subarray with a target property, rephrase as: "has a prefix with value X been seen before?"  
Store that X in a HashMap for  $O(1)$  lookup.

## Core Template

```
// MENTAL MODEL: a subarray is the difference of two prefixes; remember prefixes seen so far and look up the complement.
// WHEN: "subarray sum equals/divisible by k", "longest subarray with sum X" – anything reducible to prefix[r]-prefix[l]
Map<Long, Integer> map = new HashMap<>();
map.put(0L, ???);    // seed: empty prefix (sum=0) seen before index 0
long sum = 0;
// result = 0 (count) or Integer.MAX_VALUE (length sentinel) depending on problem

for (int i = 0; i < nums.length; i++) {
    sum += nums[i];
    long lookup = transform(sum);          // what to look up (sum-k, sum%k, etc.)
    // use map.get(lookup) → update result
    map.put(storeKey(sum), storeValue(i)); // what to store (sum or sum%k → count or index)
}
```

What changes per problem:

| Variable       | Count problems (560, 974)   | Length problems (325, 523)        |
|----------------|-----------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Map value      | count (how many times seen) | first index (earliest occurrence) |
| Seed value     | map.put(0L, 1)              | map.put(0L, -1)                   |
| On lookup hit  | count += map.get(lookup)    | maxLen = max(i - map.get(lookup)) |
| Overwrite map? | Yes (merge count)           | No (keep first index only)        |

## Quick Reference Table

Read the two map-value modes first: **count** problems store prefix sum → how many times seen and answer "how many"; **length/index** problems store prefix sum → earliest index seen and answer "how long / where". The two modes also seed differently:

- Seed  $(0, 1)$  = the empty prefix has been **seen once** before we start — needed for *counting* (a prefix that itself equals the target counts as one valid subarray).
- Seed  $(0, -1)$  = the empty prefix lives at a **virtual index -1** — needed for *length* (length from start =  $i - (-1) = i + 1$ ).

| #   | Name                               | Description                                                                                                                 | Intuition                                                                                                                       | Variation                          |
|-----|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| 560 | Subarray Sum Equals K              | Count the number of subarrays whose sum equals k.                                                                           | A subarray summing to k ends here for every earlier prefix equal to $\text{sum} - k$ ; count those prefixes.                    | Standard                           |
| 325 | Maximum Size Subarray Sum Equals k | Find the length of the longest subarray summing to k.                                                                       | Same complement as #560, but store the earliest index so $i - p$ gives the longest subarray summing to k.                       | Standard                           |
| 974 | Subarray Sums Divisible by K       | Count subarrays whose sum is divisible by k.                                                                                | Two prefixes with the same remainder bracket a subarray divisible by k; count how many share each remainder.                    | Standard                           |
| 523 | Continuous Subarray Sum            | Return true if any subarray of length $\geq 2$ has sum divisible by k.                                                      | Same-remainder pair means a divisible subarray; store the earliest index so the gap $i - p \geq 2$ proves length $\geq 2$ .     | Standard                           |
| 437 | Path Sum III                       | Count the number of paths in a binary tree that sum to targetSum. Paths can start and end at any node but must go downward. | Apply the #560 prefix-count idea along each root-to-node path; undo the prefix on the way back up so branches stay independent. | Standard                           |
| 1   | Two Sum                            | Given an array and a target, return the indices of the two numbers that add up to target.                                   | Same "have I seen the complement before?" idea as prefix-sum, but the key is the raw value, so one pass finds the pair.         | look up complement, not prefix sum |

## #560 Subarray Sum Equals K

**Description:** Count the number of subarrays whose sum equals k.

**Map:** {prefix\_sum → count}. Seed (0, 1) — the empty prefix.

**Lookup:** how many earlier prefixes equal  $\text{sum} - k$ ? Each one forms a valid subarray ending here.

**Intuition:** A subarray summing to k ends here for every earlier prefix equal to  $\text{sum} - k$ ; count those prefixes.

```
class Solution {
    public int subarraySum(int[] nums, int k) {
        Map<Long, Integer> map = new HashMap<>();
        map.put(0L, 1);
        long sum = 0;
        int count = 0;
        for (int num : nums) {
            sum += num;
            count += map.getOrDefault(sum - k, 0);
            map.merge(sum, 1, Integer::sum);
        }
        return count;
    }
}
```

**Time** O(n) | **Space** O(n)

## #325 Maximum Size Subarray Sum Equals k

**Description:** Find the length of the longest subarray summing to k.

**Map:** {prefix\_sum → first index}. Seed (0, -1) — empty prefix at virtual index -1.

**Lookup:** if  $\text{sum} - k$  was seen at index p, length =  $i - p$ . Only keep first occurrence (maximizes length).

**Intuition:** Same complement as #560, but store the earliest index so  $i - p$  gives the longest subarray summing to k.

```
class Solution {
    public int maxSubArrayLen(int[] nums, int k) {
        Map<Long, Integer> map = new HashMap<>();
        map.put(0L, -1);
        long sum = 0;
        int maxLen = 0;
        for (int i = 0; i < nums.length; i++) {
            sum += nums[i];
            if (map.containsKey(sum - k))
                maxLen = Math.max(maxLen, i - map.get(sum - k));
            if (!map.containsKey(sum)) // only store first occurrence
                map.put(sum, i);
        }
        return maxLen;
    }
}
```

**Time** O(n) | **Space** O(n)

## #974 Subarray Sums Divisible by K

**Description:** Count subarrays whose sum is divisible by k.

**Map:** {prefix\_sum % k → count}. Two subarrays share the same remainder → their difference is divisible by k.

**Lookup:** how many earlier prefixes have the same remainder?

**Watch out:** Java % can return negative — normalize with  $((\text{sum} \% k) + k) \% k$ .

**Intuition:** Two prefixes with the same remainder bracket a subarray divisible by k; count how many share each remainder.

```

class Solution {
    public int subarraysDivByK(int[] nums, int k) {
        Map<Integer, Integer> map = new HashMap<>();
        map.put(0, 1);
        int sum = 0, count = 0;
        for (int num : nums) {
            sum = ((sum + num) % k + k) % k;    // normalize negative remainders
            count += map.getOrDefault(sum, 0);
            map.merge(sum, 1, Integer::sum);
        }
        return count;
    }
}

```

**Time**  $O(n)$  | **Space**  $O(\min(n, k))$

## #523 Continuous Subarray Sum

**Description:** Return true if any subarray of length  $\geq 2$  has sum divisible by  $k$ .

**Map:**  $\{\text{prefix\_sum} \% k \rightarrow \text{first index}\}$ . Seed  $(0, -1)$ .

**Lookup:** same remainder seen before  $\rightarrow$  their difference is divisible by  $k$ . Check gap  $\geq 2$ .

**Key difference from #974:** store first index (not count), check gap, return on first hit.

**Intuition:** Same-remainder pair means a divisible subarray; store the earliest index so the gap  $i - p \geq 2$  proves length  $\geq 2$ .

```

class Solution {
    public boolean checkSubarraySum(int[] nums, int k) {
        Map<Integer, Integer> map = new HashMap<>();
        map.put(0, -1);
        int sum = 0;
        for (int i = 0; i < nums.length; i++) {
            sum = ((sum + nums[i]) % k + k) % k;    // normalize negative remainders (matches #974)
            if (map.containsKey(sum)) {
                if (i - map.get(sum) >= 2) return true;
            } else {
                map.put(sum, i);    // only store first occurrence
            }
        }
        return false;
    }
}

```

**Time**  $O(n)$  | **Space**  $O(\min(n, k))$

## #437 Path Sum III

**Description:** Count the number of paths in a binary tree that sum to `targetSum`. Paths can start and end at any node but must go downward.

**Map:**  $\{\text{prefix\_sum} \rightarrow \text{count}\}$  along the current root-to-node path. Seed  $(0, 1)$ .

**Key difference:** tree DFS — must **backtrack** (decrement count) when leaving a node, so sibling subtrees don't share state.

**Intuition:** Apply the #560 prefix-count idea along each root-to-node path; undo the prefix on the way back up so branches stay independent.

```

class Solution {
    public int pathSum(TreeNode root, int targetSum) {
        Map<Long, Integer> map = new HashMap<>();
        map.put(0L, 1);
        return dfs(root, 0L, targetSum, map);
    }

    private int dfs(TreeNode node, long sum, int target, Map<Long, Integer> map) {
        if (node == null) return 0;
        sum += node.val;
        int count = map.getOrDefault(sum - target, 0);
        map.merge(sum, 1, Integer::sum);
        count += dfs(node.left, sum, target, map);
        count += dfs(node.right, sum, target, map);
        map.merge(sum, -1, Integer::sum);    // backtrack - undo before returning
        return count;
    }
}

```

**Time**  $O(n)$  | **Space**  $O(h)$  (recursion + path-prefix map,  $h$  = tree height)

## 523 vs 974 — Side by Side

Both use `prefix sum % k` as the map key. The difference is one line:

|            |                                    |                                                        |
|------------|------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
|            | 974 (count all)                    | 523 (any length $\geq 2$ )                             |
| Map value: | count                              | first index                                            |
| Seed:      | <code>map.put(0, 1)</code>         | <code>map.put(0, -1)</code>                            |
| On hit:    | <code>count += map.get(sum)</code> | <code>if (i - map.get(sum) &gt;= 2) return true</code> |
| Store:     | <code>map.merge(sum, 1, +)</code>  | <code>map.putIfAbsent(sum, i)</code>                   |

## 560 vs 325 — Side by Side

Both use `prefix sum` as the map key, look up `sum - k`. The difference is one line:

|            |                                    |                                             |
|------------|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
|            | 560 (count all)                    | 325 (longest)                               |
| Map value: | count                              | first index                                 |
| Seed:      | <code>map.put(0L, 1)</code>        | <code>map.put(0L, -1)</code>                |
| On hit:    | <code>count += map.get(...)</code> | <code>maxLen = max(i - map.get(...))</code> |
| Store:     | <code>map.merge(sum, 1, +)</code>  | <code>map.putIfAbsent(sum, i)</code>        |

## When to Use `long` vs `int`

- Use `long` for the prefix sum when values can be large (e.g., `nums[i]` up to  $10^4 \times n$  up to  $2 \times 10^4 \rightarrow$  sum up to  $2 \times 10^8$ , safe as int, but  $10^5 \times 10^5 = 10^{10}$  overflows).
- Use `int` for the remainder key (modulo result is always in `[0, k-1]`).

### Why `0L` (not `0`) in the seed

When the map is `Map<Long, Integer>`, the seed **key** must be a `long` literal:

```

Map<Long, Integer> map = new HashMap<>();
map.put(0L, 1);    // ✓ long literal → boxes to Long (matches key type)
map.put(0, 1);    // ✗ compile error: int boxes to Integer, not Long

```

- The `L` suffix makes it a `long` literal so it autoboxes to `Long`, matching the key type (the keys are `long` because `sum` is `long` for the overflow guard above).
- Subtle trap:** even numerically equal boxes of different types never compare equal — `Long.valueOf(0).equals(Integer.valueOf(0))` is `false`. Keeping every key `long` / `Long` avoids silent lookup misses.
- If `int` sums can't overflow, use `Map<Integer, Integer>` with plain `map.put(0, 1)` instead — simpler, no `L` needed.

## #1 Two Sum

**Description:** Given an array and a `target` , return the indices of the two numbers that add up to `target` .

**Intuition:** Same "have I seen the complement before?" idea as prefix-sum, but the key is the raw value, so one pass finds the pair.

**Algorithm:** HashMap complement lookup. As you scan, for each `nums[i]` check whether its complement `target - nums[i]` was already seen. This is the same "has a value been seen before?" idea as prefix-sum problems, but the key is the raw value (not a running sum).

```
class Solution {
    public int[] twoSum(int[] nums, int target) {
        Map<Integer, Integer> map = new HashMap<>(); // value → index
        for (int i = 0; i < nums.length; i++) {
            int complement = target - nums[i];      // ← VARIATION: look up complement, not prefix sum
            if (map.containsKey(complement))
                return new int[]{map.get(complement), i};
            map.put(nums[i], i);                    // store value → index after the check
        }
        return new int[]{-1, -1};
    }
}
```

**Time**  $O(n)$  | **Space**  $O(n)$

- Always normalize Java modulo: `((sum % k) + k) % k` to handle negative inputs.